Final Project Final Report
Professional Development
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1. **Introduction**
    a. **Vision statement:**
        i. *NSA project:* I will gain a better understanding of myself as a job candidate and how I fit in the job market, have updated job search assets, complete technical interview practice, and be better connected to my local tech community.
        ii. *Philosophy/CS project:* I want to better understand the relationship between philosophy and computer science.
    b. **Goals:**
        i. *NSA project:*
            1. Continue moderating a Job Search Council (JSC) through the Never Search Alone (NSA) program, attend/lead all relevant JSC and moderator meetings, and keep members motivated via Slack
            2. Complete all NSA exercises, including the Mnookin 2 Pager, Listening Tour, and Candidate-Market Fit
            3. Update experience log, resume and LinkedIn with recent job and CSPB experience, industry best-practices, and feedback from reviewers
            4. Hone my elevator pitch
            5. Look into Mock Interview services
            6. Attend one local tech Meetup per week
            7. If time permitting: complete courses on TPM interviews, and possibly PMP exam prep
        ii. *Philosophy/CS project:*
            1. I will read the book *Think* by Simon Blackburn and document which ideas apply to Computer Science.
2. **Background**
    a. *NSA project:*
        i. I am job searching, and want clarity around what I'm looking for and roles I would be well-suited for. Additionally, I want to be better connected to the local tech scene, and prepared for job applications and interviews.

b. *Philosophy/CS project:*
    i. I want to understand the evolution of computer science concepts in order to have a better sense of where computer science and AI are currently, and where they may go in the future.

3. Methodology, Materials, and Methods

What did you use to obtain the knowledge and/or skills?

a. *NSA project:*
    i. I read the book *Never Search Alone* by Phyl Terry, and followed the process within the book.
    ii. As a participant, I had access to a Participant's website that had resources and templates for the program. I also had access to a biweekly participant webinar.
    iii. As a moderator, I also had access to a Moderator's website that contained additional resources for moderating, including weekly agendas, FAQs for each exercise, and several videos, including one on how to build trust within the team. I also had access to a biweekly moderator webinar.
    iv. I obtained the knowledge and skills by reading all of the above, and participating in the weekly exercises and Slack community.
    v. I had mock interviews and helped others with their mock interviews.
    vi. I created STAR stories
    vii. I attended tech meetups
b. *Philosophy/CS project:*
    i. I read the book *Think*, and took notes while reading.

4. Results

What did you learn?

How do you know you have learned it?

What were your project assessments, and did you reach those goals?

a. *NSA project:*
    i. I learned a lot about interviewing from getting coaching from the ex-Amazon recruiter, and also from going through the interview process myself, and talking to other tech workers about it.
    ii. I got clarity on my Candidate-Market Fit statement: *I'm looking for a Technical Program Manager role in a large tech company, based in the*

Seattle metro area, in the Fin Ops or Salesforce ecosystem. It should be hybrid or remote. The idea is to get a narrow focus so recruiters know where to place you, but you can always expand out from there.

iii. I feel ready for more interviews, now that I have my elevator pitch, 7 STAR stories plus 15 additional stories on my experience, and have had more interview experience.

iv. I expanded my tech network locally, and also through meeting my JSC. I made 21 new contacts that work at Microsoft, Meta, Google, Amazon, Okta, Autodesk, and others. I also connected with 11 classmates. I would feel comfortable reaching out to any one of these new contacts if I had a question or request for them.

v. I have the support of my JSC going forward as I continue the job search.

b. *Philosophy/CS project:*

i. I did finish the book, and came away with interesting insights from the reading. I learned the ways that philosophy contributed to modern science, physics, psychology, probability theory, law—all of which have helped shape computer science, and are currently shaping AI.

5. Discussion / Reflection

Did you meet your goals?

If yes, what did you do that allowed you to reach them?

If not, what did you do that did not allow you to reach those goals, and how would you change your approach to succeed in the future?

How do you feel about the project results?

a. *NSA project:*

i. My scores are: JSC moderation: 1; NSA exercises: 2/3; Experience log: 1; Resume / LinkedIn updates: 0; Elevator pitch: 1; Mock interviews: 1; Tech meetups: 1/3.

ii. This total is 5/7, or 71%.

iii. The reason I didn't reach my initial goals is two reasons. First, I spent a lot more time than planned on the experience log and mock interviews, since this was needed for the real interviews I had, which I hadn't anticipated in the beginning. After the interviewing, I was a bit burned out on job searching so didn't complete the resume and LinkedIn updates. Moderating also took a lot more time than anticipated. I didn't

mention before that at one point there was a conflict that I had to spend half a day working through! (That also contributed to my burn out with the JSC, although I still find it to be a great program, and it was good leadership practice.) I also was too busy to keep up with the regular tech meetups, although I did make it to quite a few early on. The second reason I didn't reach my initial goals is because I changed my project for the last two weeks.

iv. I still feel very good about my project results. I got way farther along in interview preparation than I'd planned and now feel much more confident for interviews. That was something keeping be back from applying before. I've also forged strong relations with the JSC members because of the time I put in, so I think it was all time well spent.

v. Because of this, I wouldn't change my approach in the future. Unexpected things happen, and, like in agile, sometimes more valuable things come to light after planning, and the plan has to change.

b. *Philosophy/CS project:*

i. I met this goal, although with more time, I would've like to do the 2-page write-up Professor Guinn suggested, summarizing my findings.

ii. I feel great about the knowledge I've gained from this project, and only wish I had more time to expand on it.

iii. I wouldn't have expanded this project given the time that we had, since the NSA project was very important, but if I did have more time, I think two more weeks for this project wouldn't made it feel more complete.

6. Conclusion

Look to the past, the present, and look to the future. How did this confirm/change your outlook?

What could you do next?

a. *NSA project:*

i. I definitely feel more confident applying to and interviewing for jobs, since I have a clear understanding of my candidate-market fit, have an elevator pitch, and have practiced interviewing.

ii. It confirmed my belief that the NSA program is valuable for its participants.

iii. I realized that it's important to have a lot of energy available for interviewing to go on the listening tour. This is an exercise I have not done yet (aside from meeting with an old coworker), because I wasn't ready to do all the steps of outreach and follow up that are needed. I will hopefully do this as I get back into the JSC after graduating.
iv. I had no idea how much effort interviewing at FAANG companies took, and now I have a good sense of it, as well as what resources are available.
v. I realized that Seattle has a great environment for tech meetups, and that networking is much easier than I thought it would be. It's important to plan ahead to see what events are coming up and get them on my calendar.
vi. I would like to continue meeting with my JSC, do a listening tour and update my LinkedIn and resume – as well as have 3 different versions prepared. I'd also like to keep going to tech meetups, to expand my knowledge of the topics they cover and expanding my local network. I think I should invite some of my new contacts to an upcoming event if I find a good one.

b. *Philosophy/CS project:*
   i. First, I learned that philosophy is actually not boring and a waste of time like I thought it was, but actually very interesting and important for developing new ways of thinking that can add great value to our societies.
   ii. I also learned how far back the ideas go that have influenced computer science! All of this data science / probability theory didn't just come out of the blue, from some modern math being applied to CS in order to create machine learning and AI. The knowledge base for how to do these things, and the thinking about what to apply them to, has been developed over centuries, and even millennia!
   iii. Next I would like to listen to the *Philosophize This!* Podcasts, and also the book *History of Western Philosophy* by Bertrand Russell.

7. References or Bibliography

- Terry, P. (2022). *Never search alone: The job seeker's playbook*. Collaborative Gain Inc.
- Blackburn, S. (2001). *Think: A compelling introduction to philosophy*. Oxford University Press.